

The Top 12 Reasons for Divorce

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Lack of commitment, financial challenges, and infidelity are some of the leading causes of divorce in the world. But your age and culture may change it all.

Relationship survival usually requires a blend of open communication, intimacy, and empathy. When any of these characteristics are missing or start to fade, the romantic bond between two people may weaken.

Couples may decide to divorce for many reasons. From incompatibility of lifestyles to dishonest behavior. However, researchers have found that some reasons for divorce seem to be more common across cultures and generations.

Leading causes of divorce

The top reasons for divorce have fluctuated over the years and vary by country, often heavily influenced by cultural beliefs and practices.

In Denmark, for example, a 2019 controlled trial [study](#) found the top reasons for divorce in that nation included:

- lack of love and [intimacy](#)
- [communication problems](#)
- lack of sympathy, trust, and respect
- [growing apart](#) because of different interests and activities

Couples who face challenges in having children also seem to be more likely to divorce if having a larger family is a priority for one or both partners.

Divorce percentages in the United States and the world

According to the most recent data available for the years 1970 to 2008, the average rate of divorce in 84 countries around the world was [4.08](#) for every 1,000 marriages. In the United States, the numbers are much higher.

In 2008, the [divorce rate](#) for women was 20.5 out of every 1,000 marriages, and 19.4 for men. In 2020, rates were 14 and 13.3 respectively per 1,000 marriages.

Divorce in the United States

A national [survey](#) from 2005 remains the most recent large-scale report about the leading causes of divorce in the nation.

The survey found that the 12 top reasons for divorce, from most to least common, are:

1. lack of commitment
2. constant arguing or conflict
3. infidelity
4. marrying too young
5. unrealistic expectations about partner or marriage
6. inequality between partners
7. inadequate preparation for marriage
8. domestic violence
9. financial problems
10. conflict about domestic work
11. lack of family support
12. religious differences

A smaller-scale [study](#)[Trusted Source](#) in 2013 revealed that [lack of commitment](#), infidelity, and conflict and arguing were indeed the leading causes of divorce in the United States.

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A closer look at the reasons for divorce

According to the 2005 national survey, reasons for divorce are complex, and most participants cite multiple causes for the decision.

Lack of commitment (73.2%)

A diminished desire to put effort into making your relationship work can look like poor communication, lack of compromise, or the absence of [everyday kindness](#).

Too much arguing and conflict (55%)

“Constant fighting can signify that [you’re not compatible](#) or have irreconcilable differences,” explains [Dr. Harold Hong](#), a board certified psychiatrist from Raleigh, North Carolina.

[Endless arguments](#) and poor [conflict resolution](#) may take a toll on the relationship and lead couples to divorce.

Infidelity (54.6%)

Research from 2014 suggests that [20% to 40%](#) of U.S. marriages have faced at least one [incident of infidelity](#).

“Infidelity can lead to feelings of betrayal, anger, and resentment, which can destroy a relationship,” explains [Joni Ogle](#), a licensed clinical social worker from Houston, Texas.

[Effects of infidelity](#) may include anxiety, depression, trauma, trust challenges, shame, guilt, and social withdrawal.

Marrying too young (45.7%)

Hong explains that growth and change are inevitable, but if you’re not growing together, it can put a strain on your relationship.

When you marry at a young age, you may still be [developing key aspects of your personality](#).

Signs that you may be growing apart from your spouse may include an absence of shared interests, having different life goals, and feelings of isolation or [loneliness](#), says Hong.

Unrealistic expectations (45.3%)

Unrealistic expectations about how the household will run, where you will live, and how you will be treated as a spouse are one of the top reasons for divorce in the United States.

Assuming “things will be better after you’re married” may be a warning sign of unrealistic expectations placed on the marriage.

Lack of equality (43.7%)

Early signs of inequality in a marriage might include double standards or having one partner make all the decisions.

If you feel pigeonholed into a gender stereotype in marriage, that may be another sign of inequality.

Inadequate preparation (41.1%)

Little to no pre-marriage preparation can make cohabitation overwhelming. Having a hard time living with your spouse is a leading cause of divorce.

Signs of inadequate preparation may include underdeveloped skills in home maintenance, household routines, or finance management.

Lack of preparation may also mean skipping conversations about long-term marriage goals related to children, careers, spouse roles, and preferred lifestyles.

Domestic violence (29.1%)

[Domestic violence](#) can be any pattern of abusive behavior in an intimate relationship that's used to maintain power or control.

Domestic violence isn't only about physical assault. Common signs of an abusive relationship may include persistent blaming, intimidation, [manipulation](#), and social isolation.

Financial problems (28.4%)

Having a hard time making ends meet or having a partner who overextends spending may cause stress in a marriage.

If you're always being asked for money, it may be a sign your partner finds financial responsibility a challenge.

Unresolved financial challenges are one of the top reasons for divorce.

Conflict about domestic work (21.6%)

Unequal distribution of household chores and child care responsibilities may translate into conflict and resentment for one or both partners.

Feeling your spouse takes you for granted or that you can't rely on them for support may lead many couples to divorce.

Lack of family support (18.7%)

If your family doesn't agree with your marriage or your partner, the rift you feel may contribute to feelings of isolation and loneliness, as well as a sense of grief for the lost connections.

Your family may exclude your partner, put them down, or encourage you to "keep your options open."

Both you and your partner may find this pressure difficult to manage, which could cause you to consider divorce as an option.

Religious differences (13.2%)

"If you and your partner have different values, it can be tough to find common ground," says Ogle.

If your partner ridicules or demeans your religion early in the relationship, or tries to convert you away despite your expressed disinterest, it may be an indicator of future conflict.

Should couples try separation before divorcing?

There is no evidence that couples may benefit from a separation before considering divorce.

According to Hong, [research](#) shows the majority of separations progress to the divorce phase anyway.

Separating can, however, be beneficial when both partners are invested in reconciling and just need some time to regroup.

"Some couples may find that a temporary separation can help them identify and resolve the underlying problems in their marriage," says Hong. "Separation can give you time to reflect on your relationship and decide if you want to stay married or not."

Do reasons for divorce change depending on age?

Reasons for divorce don't change depending on age, but challenges may manifest differently.

[Research](#) in 2019 spanning several decades noted that divorce rates *do* vary depending on age groups. [Dr. Danielle McGraw](#), a licensed clinical psychologist from Scottsdale, Arizona, points out the reasons are often the same, though.

"The causes don't necessarily change between age groups, but they may look different," she explains.

McGraw indicates that older couples may have learned to avoid conflict, for example, whereas younger couples may experience more fighting in the relationship. Still, unresolved conflict is a leading cause of divorce for both young and older couples.

Medically reviewed

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How hard should you try before getting a divorce?

All three experts agree: No matter how hard you try, saving a marriage is only possible if both people share that goal.

"A couple can only [heal a relationship](#) and avoid divorce if both parties are willing to work on the relationship and communicate effectively," says Ogle.

Where there's mutual love, even if complicated by reconcilable differences and [communication barriers](#), marriage can be salvaged.

"In most situations, it is possible to [heal a relationship with therapy](#)," says McGraw. "Couples therapy can help couples learn communication skills, learn how to [express their feelings](#) to one another, express their needs, and rebuild their friendship."

McGraw adds that safety is a priority when it comes to saving a relationship. When physical, emotional, and mental health are in jeopardy in marriage, separation or divorce may be the best option.

Let's recap

Infidelity, arguing, infertility, and lack of commitment are some of the top reasons for divorce in the world. There's usually more than one cause of divorce, though.

Most divorce reasons are preventable, though, when both partners are in love and willing to spend time and energy in solving the differences.

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Reasons For Divorce: Top 10 Reason Why Marriages Fail



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Key Takeaways

- Open up with honest communication by listening with curiosity and checking in daily to understand each other's needs and feel seen, building trust and closeness together.
- Prioritize emotional and physical intimacy by showing small acts of kindness and carving regular time for connection to deepen your bond.
- Grow together through support and equality by treating each other as partners, seeking counseling if needed, and addressing misunderstandings as a team.

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You know things are not going well for you and your spouse. Your partner seemed stern, aloof, and resentful that last time you spoke to each other.

Like always, you expect them to come around, let go of the steam and become their normal self with time. Instead, one day, you come home to find their clothes missing from their cupboards and a piece of paper on the dinner table- a divorce notice.

What causes divorce in marriage?

Infidelity, [lack of communication](#), financial troubles, and lack of sex and intimacy are some of the most common reasons for divorce.

The Austin Institute for The Study of Family and Culture, using data from 4,000 divorced adults, identified the top reasons for divorce to clarify why people break up in the United States. These reasons include infidelity by

either party; one spouse being unresponsive to the other's needs; incompatibility; spouse immaturity; emotional abuse, and financial problems.

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There are some traits in a partner or circumstances- the divorce causes which might force partners to seek a divorce.

You can no longer cope with your partner, and divorce is perhaps the best option.

When couples feel like they have given their relationship all they have, they can ultimately come to the conclusion that it's time to [end their marriage](#).

Do you think this scenario could transpire in your life?

It's not uncommon that couples start to fight and make up until one day, they fall apart for good. Don't neglect your [relationship issues](#). You never know, your relationship could be treading towards rocky roads too!

What are the top 10 reasons for divorce?

Here is a list of commonly observed grounds for divorce, coupled with reasons for divorce statistics. If you identify any of these in your relationship, you must get conscious about where your relationship is heading.

This will help you understand what factors are associated with a higher risk for divorce and take the necessary actions to avert further damage.

Let's look at the 10 most common reasons for divorce and understand whether or not your marriage is salvageable.

1. Infidelity or an extramarital affair

When one person goes outside of the relationship to get their needs met, whether it is physical or sexual, this can doom a relationship. It is very [difficult to get trust back once a partner feels betrayed](#).

Extra-marital affairs are the number one reason for divorce and responsible for the [20-40% breakdown](#) of most marriages that end in divorce. This is one of the most common causes of divorce. The [reasons why people cheat](#) aren't as cut and dry as our anger may lead us to believe.

[Anger and resentment](#) are common underlying reasons for cheating, along with differences in sexual appetite and [lack of emotional intimacy](#).

Infidelity often begins as a seemingly innocent friendship, says cheating expert Ruth Houston. “It starts as an [emotional affair](#) which later becomes a physical affair.”

Infidelity is one of the primary reasons for divorce. It is also one of the legal divorce reasons, besides living apart for more than a year and subjecting your partner to cruelty (mental or physical).

2. Trouble with finances

Money makes people funny, or so the saying goes, and it’s true.

If a couple is not on the same page about [how the finances are going to be handled](#), it can lead to terrible problems.

Why is divorce so common due to financial incompatibility? According to [divorce statistics](#), a “final straw” reason for divorce is a lack of compatibility in the financial arena, which causes almost 41% of divorces.

Everything from different spending habits and financial goals to one spouse making considerably more money than the other, causing a power struggle can strain a marriage to the breaking point.

Also, differences in how much money each partner brings into the marriage can also lead to power plays between a couple.

“Money really touches everything. It impacts people’s lives,” said Emmet Burns, brand marketing director for SunTrust. Clearly, money and stress do seem to go hand in hand for many couples.

Financial troubles can be categorized as one of the biggest causes of divorce, following infidelity, the number one reason for divorce.

RELATED READING : [6 Key Ways to Manage Financial Disagreements in Marriage](#)

3. Lack of communication

Communication is crucial in marriage, and not being able to communicate effectively quickly leads to resentment and frustration for both, impacting all aspects of a marriage.

On the other hand, [good communication](#) is the foundation of a strong marriage. When two people are sharing a life together, they must be able to talk about what they need and be able to understand and try to meet the needs of their partner.

Yelling at your spouse, not talking enough throughout the day, and making nasty comments to express yourself are all unhealthy methods of communication that need to be ditched in a marriage.

Besides, when couples stop talking to each other, they can [feel isolated and lonely](#) and stop caring about one another altogether. This can lead to the breakdown of the relationship.

[Poor communication](#) is one of the biggest reasons for 65% of divorces.

[Practicing mindful communication](#) to change age-old marriage mistakes can be hard, but it's well worth the effort to improve and save your relationship.

4. Constant arguing

From bickering about chores to arguing about the kids; incessant arguing kills many relationships.

Couples who seem to [keep having the same argument over again](#) often do so because they feel they're not being heard or appreciated.

Many find it hard to see the other person's point of view, which leads to a lot of arguments without ever coming to a resolution. This can ultimately be a [cause of divorce for 57.7% of couples](#).

5. Weight gain

It may seem awfully superficial or unfair, but weight gain is one of the main reasons for divorce.

It may seem odd, but weight gain is also one of the leading causes of divorce. In some cases, a significant amount of weight gain causes the other spouse to become less physically attracted to the other, while for others, weight gain takes a toll on their self-esteem, which trickles into [issues with intimacy](#) and can even become a cause of divorce.

6. Unrealistic expectations

It's easy to [go into a marriage with lofty expectations](#), expecting your spouse and the marriage to live up to your image of what they should be.

These expectations can put a lot of strain on the other person, leaving you feeling let down and setting your spouse up for failure. Faulty expectation setting can become one of the reasons for divorce.

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7. Lack of intimacy

[Not feeling connected to your partner](#) can quickly ruin a marriage because it leaves couples feeling as though they're living with a stranger or more like roommates than spouses.

This can be from a [lack of physical or emotional intimacy](#) and isn't always about sex. If you are constantly giving your spouse the cold shoulder, know that it can become the ground for divorce over time.

Often, couples struggle with different sex drives and different sexual appetites. This is the beginning of the troubles and can really plague a couple as they try to get their needs met. In addition, at different stages of life, our sexual needs can change, which can lead to feelings of confusion and rejection.

Ignoring your partner's sexual needs is being called the number one cause of divorce in recent times.

Making your relationship intimate and special is the responsibility of both partners. Practice little acts of kindness, appreciation, and [enjoy physical intimacy](#) as much as possible to sweeten your relationship.

8. Lack of equality

Lack of equality comes closely behind the number one cause of divorce, lack of intimacy, in recent times.

When one partner feels that they take on more responsibility in the marriage, it can alter their view of the other person and [lead to resentment](#).

Resentment often snowballs to become one of the reasons for divorce. It is a leading cause of divorce.

Every couple must negotiate through their own unique set of challenges and find their own way of [living together as two equals](#) who enjoy a respectful, harmonious, and joyful relationship.

9. Not being prepared for marriage

A surprising proportion of [75% of couples](#) of all ages have blamed not being prepared for married life for the demise of their relationship. [Divorce rates are highest](#) among couples in their 20s. Lack of preparation is one of the most common reasons for divorce.

Almost half the divorces occur in the first 10 years of marriage, especially between the fourth and eighth anniversary.

10. Physical and emotional abuse

Physical or emotional abuse is a sad reality for some couples and contributes to [23.5% of divorces](#).

It doesn't always stem from the abuser being a "bad" person; deep emotional issues are usually to blame. Regardless of the reason, no one should tolerate abuse, and you must remove yourself from the relationship safely.

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What percentage of marriages end in divorce?

The picture of what percentage of marriages end in divorce might seem predictably low, but the reality is that approximately 50% of marriages end up in divorce in the United States.

Not just this, according to statistics, couples usually divorce in the first seven years of marriage. So, [what year of marriage is divorce most common?](#)

It is said that marital satisfaction increases as the couple moves toward their 10th anniversary.

If you think you know why people get divorced or [how many marriages end in divorce](#), you might not be wrong, but there are certain reasons to get a divorce that you could never have guessed.

RELATED READING : [Things to consider before you Divorce: The Pros & Cons of Divorce](#)

Are there "good" reasons to get a divorce?

You might question yourself, "Should I divorce my spouse or stick in the marital bond?"

Well, the answer completely depends on your experience in marriage. Every relationship is unique, and it's on the couple to decide how they want to proceed in the relationship.

Besides, if you feel the relationship is serving you no purpose and it is only giving you suffering, it is a good decision to walk away from marriage.

If you are still unsure, take this quiz and find out the answer:

RELATED QUIZ : [Should You Get A Divorce? Take This Quiz And Find Out](#)

How couples therapy can salvage your marriage?

If you are experiencing one or more of these [issues in your marriage](#), you may be having a pretty tough time right now.

Here's the good news. [Couples therapy](#) can really help with any or all of these issues. Typically couples come to marriage therapy seven to eleven years after problems have started. That can make it seem pretty hopeless that things will ever get better.

However, if both partners are committed to making their marriage better, a lot can be done to improve their life together and help them [save their marriage](#).

Frequently Asked Questions

In cases where divorce seems on the horizon, here's what you should know before moving forward:

- How to file a divorce

The first step to filing a divorce is initiating a divorce petition. This leads to temporary orders that are served to the spouse, and then you await the response. Next, there is a settlement negotiation, after which the divorce trial starts. To know more, find here [how to file for a legal separation](#).

- How long does the divorce process take?

Divorce is carried out with the mutual consent of both parties. In such cases, the divorce timeline is nearly six months. However, a petition cannot be filed within the 1st year of marriage. Also, the first two motions require a six-month gap. The court also holds the power to waive the cooling-off period. To know more, read an article on [how long the divorce process takes](#).

- How much does a divorce cost?

The cost of a divorce has a wide range between \$7500 to \$12,900 as it depends on various factors. Check out this quick guide on how much does a divorce cost.

- What is the difference between legal separation and divorce?

Legal separation gives a lot of space to the couple for settlement and to get back together. Divorce, on the other hand, is the final step after which the reconciliation is out of the legal books. Here's an article for you to understand the [differences between separation and divorce](#).

- Do you have to disclose all of your finances during divorce?

While going through the divorce, the partners must disclose fully to each other and discuss their assets for a fair settlement. Read this article to get answers to the question [of how to achieve a fair financial settlement during a divorce](#).

- How do courts divide property in a divorce?

In the case of the division of property, mutual understanding plays a big role. In most cases, the courts consider the division based on who is the legal owner of the property. Also, if the couples agree on their own adjustment, the court does not object. Check out the article to know more about [how property and debts will be divided in divorce](#).

- How to find a divorce lawyer

Once you understand that divorce is on the horizon, you must find an attorney to represent you. It can be wise to consult with three different attorneys. Discuss the issue with each and decide which one will be able to help you best. Read this article if you need help in [finding the right divorce lawyer](#).

- How to obtain a divorce certificate

For obtaining the divorce certificate, you must contact the court clerk where the divorce proceedings took place. Obtaining the divorce certificate can only be done by either party or their lawyers. Check out the article on [how to get a divorce certificate](#).

- Who initiates divorce more?

There is no definitive answer as to who initiates divorce more, as it can vary based on individual circumstances.

Historically, women have initiated divorce [more frequently](#), but recent studies suggest that the gender gap is narrowing. Factors such as cultural shifts, evolving gender roles, and individual motivations all play a role in divorce initiation.

- **How do you know it's time for a divorce?**

Knowing when it's time for a divorce and why are divorce rates so high can be subjective, but some common signs include constant arguing, loss of trust, emotional or physical abuse, lack of intimacy, or when both partners feel unhappy and unable to resolve their differences despite efforts to communicate and seek help.

- Getting help from divorce therapists

A person going through a divorce can go through various emotions of guilt, anger, loneliness, etc. At such times, they might need a professional to help understand their problems and also so that they can tread on the path of healing.

Divorce therapists help people [cope with the stress of divorce](#) and guide them toward a more peaceful life. In some instances, they also help couples analyze if they are sure of the divorce. [Find the right therapist](#) based on what your core issue is.

Takeaway

No marriage is easy. How many marriages end in divorce varies depending on various factors such as geographical location, cultural norms, and individual circumstances.

Even couples with the best intentions are sometimes unable to overcome their challenges and end up in courtrooms. That's why it's important to address issues in your relationship early on; don't let them become one of the reasons for divorce. Don't wait until they are beyond fixing.

Try your very best before you decide that things are beyond your control; there are too many reasons for divorce, and you may be able to spot these reasons before it's too late. If you catch issues early, you can work on resolving them.

That way, you can have the peace of knowing you tried all of the alternatives before the big step. Divorce is one of the worst things you can experience emotionally, but sometimes, it's inevitable and for the best.

Practice kindness, make intimacy a priority, go on holidays, and seek marriage counseling (even when things are fine) to preserve the health and longevity of your relationship.

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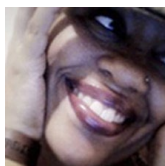
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I realized I felt more relief imagining leaving than fear. That scared me, but it was also really telling.

M

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Therapy helped me separate a rough season from long-term patterns I'd been ignoring.

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What Causes Divorce? 8 Common Reasons for Divorce

Learn what research says about the most common reasons for divorce, how those reasons differ from legal grounds for divorce, and early signs these issues might be showing up in your own marriage.

By [E.A. Gjelten](#), Legal Editor

Updated 4/24/2026

Social scientists who study marriage have found that the reasons couples give for divorce tend to cluster around a few big themes: lack of commitment, incompatibility over time, poor communication, infidelity, money conflicts, substance abuse, domestic abuse, and disputes over family responsibilities.

In this article, we've pulled together the results from several of the best studies (see details below) and ranked the top eight reasons people say their marriages ended by how often they came up. Before you dive into the list, keep in mind that most divorces have more than one cause. People often point to several problems that feed into each other. For example, people are more likely to have extramarital affairs when they're experiencing other problems in their marriage, and communication problems exacerbate issues like money disputes. Another complicating factor that won't surprise you is that couples often disagree about what caused their breakup.

Still, it can be helpful to learn what other people say about why their marriages ended, with the benefit of hindsight. And if you're hoping to avoid the same outcome, it can help to recognize signs of these problems that might show up in your own marriage.

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First Name

Most divorces now go forward on no-fault grounds even when the spouses believe one partner is mainly at fault.

1. Lack of Commitment to the Marriage

In several studies that asked people to choose from a list of important reasons for their divorce, lack of commitment came out at the top of the list. (As many as 85% of participants in one study gave this answer.) Interestingly enough, another study showed that lack of commitment was also the reason couples were most likely to agree on, although one spouse usually blamed the other for not working harder to save the marriage.

Lack of commitment can seem vague and hard to prove (or disprove), especially to the person who's being blamed for the problem. The outward signs are often related to other reasons for divorce, like extramarital affairs, not being willing to talk about the relationship, and not working toward shared financial goals. That's probably why

so many people point to a lack of commitment as a significant cause of divorce—because they see it as the issue underlying a range of more obvious problems.

Legal Divorce Grounds vs. the “Real” Reasons Marriages End

On a legal level, whether you have a “legitimate” reason for ending your marriage depends on the [grounds for divorce](#) allowed under your state’s laws.

All states allow some version of “no-fault divorce.” In this kind of divorce, instead of assigning blame for the breakup, the divorce petition may simply claim one of the no-fault grounds permitted in your state—usually a reason like “irreconcilable differences” or an “irretrievable breakdown” in your marriage. Of course, those legal no-fault grounds don’t explain what caused a marriage to break beyond repair.

Some states allow one spouse to legally blame the other for a divorce. Examples of legal grounds for a “fault” divorce include adultery, physical abuse, emotional abuse, and habitual substance abuse. Even so, most divorces now go forward on no-fault grounds even when the spouses believe one partner is mainly at fault.

2. Incompatibility: Growing Apart Over Time

All those lawmakers who settled on “irreconcilable differences” as the basic ground for no-fault divorce were on to something. When asked why their marriages ended, a significant proportion of divorced people answer with some variation of “we grew apart,” “we drifted apart,” or “we were just incompatible” (up to 55% in one study). This concept of incompatibility could include other divorce reasons that came up in various studies, such as:

- a lack of shared values
- marrying too young (which makes growing apart more likely)
- sexual difficulties, and
- religious differences.

Of course, many couples live with and even relish their differences. But most successful marriages are based on a core of shared (or at least overlapping) interests, priorities, and values. Outward signs of incompatibility often go hand in hand with other common reasons for divorce—especially poor communication, which is next on the list.

3. Communication Problems

Around 50% of participants in various studies cited reasons for divorce that had to do with poor communication, like arguing too much and not being able to talk to each other. Here again, communication problems can be the cause of other reasons people give for divorce, such as conflict over money and family responsibilities.

It’s not hard to recognize when you’re arguing all the time with your spouse. But even if the fights aren’t that frequent or nasty, keep an eye out for repeated arguments about the same thing or disagreements that never really get resolved. That can be a sign that you need help learning how to communicate with each other more effectively, perhaps through couples therapy.

4. Extramarital Affairs

Although [infidelity](#) (or adultery) came up in every study we reviewed, its frequency among the reasons given for divorce varied from about 20% in one study to 60% in others.

This wide range could be a reflection of the fact that at least some divorced people consider an affair just the last straw after a string of other marital problems. Those other problems might be the reason someone goes outside the marriage for intimacy, excitement, or distraction—or even as an unconscious way of provoking the other spouse into calling an end to the marriage.

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5. Financial Incompatibility: Money Disagreements

In different studies, about 40% of people said that financial problems—in particular, complaints about how their ex-spouse handled money—were a major reason they got divorced. Fights over money are often referred to as “financial incompatibility,” because they usually stem from differences in priorities and values around financial decisions.

Signs that you and your spouse are financially incompatible include when:

- one of you keeps secrets or even outright lies about purchases or other financial decisions (like making investments or withdrawing money from savings)
- one of you doesn't consult the other before making large purchases or taking other steps that affect your joint finances
- you can't talk regularly (and calmly) about your finances

- the two of you can't or won't set joint financial goals (like budgeting and saving to buy a house, have kids, or build a retirement nest egg), and
- you set financial goals together, but one of you keeps subverting them.

Not surprisingly, research has shown that couples with lower incomes are more likely to cite financial incompatibility as a major reason for getting divorced. When there's less to go around—and higher stress about being able to pay bills—there's likely to be more fighting over money issues. And of course, no matter a couple's income level, fights about [money and property continue during the divorce itself](#).

6. Substance Abuse and Addiction

In various studies, between 10% and 35% of people said they divorced because of their spouse's drinking or drug problems.

There are many [signs that your spouse could have a substance use disorder](#), including:

- changes in sleep, appetite, and hygiene
- secretive behavior
- sudden mood swings
- paranoia or other personality changes
- neglecting work or family responsibilities
- abandoning old friends or activities
- an unexplained need for extra money, and
- difficulties with attention or memory.

(Learn [how alcohol and drug use affects custody decisions in divorce](#).)

7. Domestic Violence and Abuse

Between 15% and 25% of participants in various studies listed [domestic violence](#) as an important reason for divorce. And in a study focusing on [older divorced couples](#), more than a third of participants listed verbal, emotional, or physical abuse as one of the three main reasons for their divorce.

Women and men tend to have very different views of domestic abuse as a cause of divorce. In one national study, 42% of women—but only 9% of men—cited domestic violence as an important reason their marriage ended. That could be a reflection of the fact that [women are much more likely than men to suffer intimate partner abuse](#), and that victims of abuse are more likely than abusers to see the behavior as the cause of divorce.

Learn about the [warning signs of relationship abuse](#) and [how to protect yourself when leaving an abusive relationship](#).

Safety and Privacy Considerations for Victims

Be sure to consider the privacy of your computer, smartphone, or tablet when seeking help online or over the phone. Some victims might use the same device, network, or phone plan as the abuser, allowing the abuser to see the victim's search or call history or otherwise track their activity. (Of course, these aren't the only ways abusers can secretly monitor victims.)

Several organizations provide assistance and resources regarding internet privacy and physical safety, including [National Domestic Violence Hotline](#), [Safety Net](#), and [RAINN](#).

8. Conflicts Over Family Responsibilities

When some studies asked about the important reasons for divorce, about 20% of participants cited conflicts in their marriage over:

- how to raise their kids
- child care responsibilities, and/or
- other family and household obligations.

It's worth noting that at least one study showed women were significantly more likely than men to cite these disputes as an important cause of their divorce. In older studies that gave participants a checklist of reasons,

the lists seldom included conflicts over family responsibilities—perhaps because many social scientists overlooked or made assumptions about gender roles in marriages between men and women.

Some Divorce Reasons Matter More Than Others

As we've noted, this list of top divorce reasons is based on our review of a number of research studies. It accounts for how often people, looking back at their own divorce, identified these as [significant causes](#), not how severe the issues are when they happen. As one obvious example, any form of domestic violence is normally more serious than communication problems.

Couples who divorce after the age of 50, sometimes called a [gray divorce](#), give additional reasons for ending their unions that range from empty nest syndrome to a spouse's serious health problems.

Of course, every marriage is unique, and the vast majority of couples face at least one of the problems on this list at some point in their relationship. But while some issues are more harmful than others (like domestic abuse and serious substance abuse disorders), most [don't have to lead to divorce](#)—as long as both spouses are willing to work together to save the marriage. That might help explain why a lack of commitment was at the top of the list in multiple studies.

About Our Methods and Sources

Many of the research studies we reviewed offered participants checklists of possible causes of divorce, and those lists often differed from study to study. In other studies, participants were allowed to come up with their own divorce reasons, which naturally resulted in a wide variety of responses. Still, across the research, many of the important reasons people gave for their divorce pointed to similar issues that came up again and again. So we compiled our list by comparing and consolidating the most common of those issues. This article was based on a review of numerous research studies, including: [Reasons for Divorce and Recollections of Premarital Intervention: Implications for Improving Relationship Education](#), S.B. Scott et al., *Couple Family Psychology*, 2013:2(2); [Reasons for Divorce and Openness to Marital Reconciliation](#), A.J. Hawkins et al., *Journal of Divorce & Remarriage*, 2012:53(6); [With This Ring...A National Survey on Marriage in America](#), National Fatherhood Initiative, 2005; [The Divorce Experience: A Study of Divorce at Midlife and Beyond](#), X.P. Montenegro, AARP, 2004; [People's Reasons for Divorcing: Gender, Social Class, the Life Course, and Adjustment](#), P.R. Amato and D. Previti, *Journal of Family Issues*, 2003:24(5); [Marriage in Oklahoma: 2001 Baseline Statewide Survey on Marriage and Divorce](#), C.A. Johnson, et al., OSU Bureau for Social Research, 2001; [Reasons for Divorce: Perspective of Divorcing Men and Women](#), L. Gigy and J.B. Kelly, *Journal of Divorce and Remarriage*, 1993:18(1-2); [Sociodemographic Perspectives on Reasons for Divorce](#), M. Thurnher, et al., *Journal of Divorce*, 1983:6(4).

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Summarize this Ask AI Assistant

Written By:

[Liz Sauls](#)

CEO and Founder, Divorce.com

Causes Of Divorce: 19 Of The Most Common Reasons

What are the most common reasons for divorce? Of course, this is a subjective question, as the reasons people get divorced are as varied as the reasons they fall in love.

However, certain issues arise more often: conflict, infidelity, poor communication, incompatibility, and a lack of romantic intimacy. Even though the overall divorce rate is decreasing among adults aged 16 to 65, [approximately 45% of marriages](#) in the US still end in divorce.

Read on to learn about the 19 most common reasons people decide to divorce.

What Are The Most Common Causes of Divorce?

According to various studies, the four most common causes of divorce are lack of commitment, infidelity or extramarital affairs, too much conflict and arguing, and lack of physical intimacy. The least common reasons are lack of shared interests and incompatibility between partners.

1. Too Much Conflict, Incessant Arguing

Constant conflict, bitter battles, and going to bed angry every night are no one's idea of a healthy marriage.

"How you handle conflict is the single most important predictor of whether your marriage will survive."

How long could you stick it out when your home – which is supposed to be your place of peace and release from the daily grind – is more stressful than your worst day at work? In a good marriage, your spouse is your partner, your shelter from the storm, and your number-one cheerleader when you're down.

In a high-conflict marriage, your spouse is as emotionally dangerous as a terrible boss. Unless interrupted by [marriage counseling](#) or therapy, this negative spiral will continue downward until the only place left to go is divorce.

Related Reading

2. Lack of Commitment

A happy and healthy marriage requires commitment from both spouses. Unfortunately, it only takes one spouse with a lack of commitment to the relationship to doom the marriage. If one partner isn't fully committed to the other, then the marriage will eventually suffer.

Sometimes, the spouse who is still committed to the relationship believes they can singlehandedly save their marriage if they work harder at it. After all, if they put in 200% while their spouse puts in 0%, that equals 100% – right?

When their marriage inevitably ends, after the shock and disbelief have worn off, their rage at being used and taken for granted during the relationship may lead to a very difficult divorce.

3. Infidelity / Extramarital Affairs

Being cheated on by the person who vowed to remain faithful to you forever is a bitter pill to swallow, and most people consider this to be an unforgivable offense. Infidelity doesn't always lead to divorce, but it does destroy how you see your relationship.

Discovering that your spouse has been engaging in an extramarital affair makes you ask three questions:

1. Can my marriage survive this betrayal?
2. Can I ever trust my spouse/partner again?
3. Am I willing to work on my marriage, or is my partner's infidelity the last straw?

The answer to these questions depends on whether both of you are willing and able to repair your relationship – almost certainly with the help of a [marriage and family therapist \(MFT\)](#).

To rescue your relationship, you will have to forgive your partner – and your partner will have to make a genuine apology and commit to acting to end their cheating for good. If you have been drifting apart, focus on reconnecting rather than pointing fingers and playing the blame game.

4. Lack of Emotional and/or Physical Intimacy

Emotional and physical intimacy “grease the wheels” of a smooth-running relationship. When they’re gone, however, serious relationship issues often take their place.

Communication breakdown, anger, resentment, sadness, loneliness, infidelity, and greatly diminished self-esteem are some of the most serious issues – and left untreated, they can irreparably damage a relationship and pave the road to divorce.

When [emotional intimacy](#) is low or non-existent, your sex life will probably suffer as well. When you feel emotionally distant or disconnected from your spouse, your marriage may become a sexless one.

To reignite the spark, try to remember why you fell in love with your spouse and consciously view them through those lenses.

Also, think about what you used to love doing together and carve out time to do those things together again. Spending quality time doing something you both enjoy can help rebuild emotional intimacy, leading to physical intimacy.

Emotional and physical intimacy is like super-glue to strengthen your love and marriage bonds.

5. Communication Problems Between Partners

A breakdown in the lines of communication is one of the biggest predictors of divorce. Couples who don’t communicate well cannot resolve issues together and tend to suffer more misunderstandings and hurt feelings than those who have learned how to resolve conflict respectfully.

Good communication is physical as well as verbal, and it is required for almost everything in a good relationship, including sex, a couple’s finances, whether or not to have children, areas of disagreement, and other sensitive topics unhappy couples deem too dangerous to discuss.

An inability to communicate turns problem-solving sessions into shouting matches, which will eventually kill love, intimacy, and respect in your relationship.

To make it through the inevitable tough times, you must be willing and able to talk about what’s wrong or not working and decide how to resolve these issues together.

“Being able to communicate well requires both good transmission skills (articulation) and good receptive skills (listening). Without both, communication will be, at best, difficult.”

6. Domestic Violence: Abuse by a Partner or Parent

Domestic violence can include any act of tangible or threatened abuse – including verbal, physical, sexual, emotional, and/or economic abuse. In such a relationship, one person gains or maintains power over their partner via a pattern of abusive behavior.

This abuse can be directed solely at a spouse, or it can also involve one or more children of the marriage. If you or your children are in immediate danger, call 911 now!

For 24/7 confidential help, call the [National Domestic Violence](#) Hotline at 1-800-799-7233 (SAFE) or 1-800-787-3224 (TTY).

In October 2022, the National Coalition Against Domestic Violence (NCADV) and the National Domestic Violence Hotline (The Hotline) merged to form [Project Opal](#).

For more resources, visit: <https://ncadv.org/get-help>

7. Opposing Values or Morals

There have been literal wars fought over differences in race, religion, nationality, and culture – and persecution based on all of these, plus gender, sexuality, and even which political party someone supports.

When two spouses have or develop opposing values and/or morals, and neither can or is willing to see things from their spouse’s point of view, the marriage is likely to end in divorce.

She believes in a woman's right to choose, and he believes life begins at conception; his best friend is gay, and his wife is homophobic. They fell in love despite their religious difference, but those differences are tearing them apart now that they have children.

When you're in love, you tend to overlook or rationalize red flags that your core values and morals are too different for a healthy relationship – but when the rose-colored glasses come off, those differences make it difficult or impossible to sustain a happy marriage.

Related Reading

8. Addiction: Alcohol, Drugs, Gambling, or Sex

There are many different types and degrees of addiction, and many top professionals – politicians, businesspeople, doctors, lawyers, portfolio managers, actors, and athletes, to name a few – have been able to hide their addiction successfully as they rose to the top.

Their spouses may be blissfully unaware, willing to look the other way in return for lifestyle/economic benefits, or gaslighted into believing they're crazy to suspect their spouse's addiction. No matter how the moment of truth arrives, it is always shattering.

Whether the marriage can survive depends on several factors – including the addict's willingness and ability to take responsibility for their addiction, a genuine desire to seek treatment, and a lifelong commitment to recovery.

9. Absence of Romantic Intimacy or Love

This one is far too common given how busy and stressful our lives are – especially when you add driving the kids to football/hockey/baseball/ballet/orchestra/theater/choir practice before and after school into the mix.

Too many couples prioritize everything except their relationships, and then one partner is blindsided when the other says, "I want a divorce." Contrary to popular belief, romantic love is not self-sustaining: without carving out quality time for intimacy and fun as a couple – not just as a family – love withers like a plant without water or sunshine.

Create a weekly carved-in-stone date night. For example, go to bed, wake up earlier, and use the time for daily physical (cuddling and/or sex) and emotional intimacy. Remember what you loved doing while you were dating, then start doing those things again before it's too late!

10. One Spouse Not Carrying Their Weight in the Marriage

We all know marriages like this: both spouses work full-time, but only one of them takes responsibility for grocery shopping and cooking, household chores, and child-rearing.

Over time, the spouse whose work doesn't end when they get home can build up a powerful resentment against the other, and unless the situation is addressed and rectified, the marriage could spiral down into divorce.

Sit down and list everything that needs to be done to keep the household running smoothly. Then, place a name beside each task, making sure to divide the chores equitably.

Don't forget to add your children's names to tasks they are old enough to tackle or help with – from setting the table to washing the dishes to mowing the lawn to vacuuming the carpets.

"Not carrying your weight" extends to romance and intimacy; if one partner is the only one making romantic gestures, arranging date nights, or initiating sex, that will also take a toll on the marriage.

11. Financial Problems and Debt

Money has been tight for many couples over the last few years. Arguments about money can become nasty and vindictive – and if a couple lacks the communication skills to discuss their financial problems calmly and rationally, that can be a reason for divorce.

In a marriage, [financial problems](#) are not limited to carrying massive debt and/or being unable to cover necessities. When the way spouses think about money and debt – no matter how much or how little of it they actually have – are fundamentally incompatible, it can also cause the breakdown of a marriage.

If financial problems are your main issue, consider hiring an expert specializing in financial divorce issues. They could save money by recommending the most efficient property division, tax, and support strategies.

A divorce financial analyst can also provide scenarios extrapolating your cash flow and net worth 5, 10, or even 20 years into the future if you choose Settlement A vs. Settlement B.

12. Marrying Too Young

A study from the University of Utah suggests that the perfect age to get married is [between 28 and 32](#). This is because those who marry young most likely don't fully grasp marriage. This could be a reason why a lot of young married couples get divorced.

About 46% of couples who get married young get divorced. Also, 48% of couples who marry before they turn 18 are most likely to get divorced in 10 years, compared to 25% of people who marry after the age of 25.

13. Lack of Shared Interests / Incompatibility Between Partners

Opposites may attract, but similarities are what bind. With no shared interests, you will either start spending less and less time with your spouse as you pursue your hobbies and passions or give them up in favor of your spouse's interests.

Both of these strategies will build resentment and weaken the bond you share. If you hope to stay together, you will likely need marriage counseling and a willingness to compromise.

For example, if he loves bowling and she loves dancing, he could bowl with his buddies on Thursdays while she goes dancing with her girlfriends – and then they identify something they both love and do that on “Friday date night.”

This applies to every area of your shared life, from household chores to choosing which extracurricular activities their children will do. If you cannot reach a compromise that both of you can commit to, your incompatibility may lead to divorce.

14. Religious Differences

Religious beliefs and practices play a pivotal role in shaping an individual's worldview, values, and daily rituals.

When two partners come from different religious backgrounds, it can sometimes lead to disagreements on fundamental life choices, from dietary habits to child-rearing practices.

While many interfaith couples find ways to blend their beliefs and traditions, for others harmoniously, the differences can become a source of recurring conflict. The challenge often lies in reconciling deeply held beliefs and finding common ground, especially during significant life events or ceremonies.

In some cases, external pressures from family or the broader community can exacerbate these differences.

Religious differences can significantly lead to marital discord without open communication and mutual respect.

15. Parenting Differences

Parenting is one of the most rewarding yet challenging responsibilities a couple can undertake together.

Differences in parenting styles, stemming from individual upbringings, personal beliefs, or cultural backgrounds, can become a significant source of tension in a marriage. While one partner might advocate for a more disciplined approach, the other might lean towards a lenient and nurturing style.

These disparities can lead to disagreements, ranging from education choices to setting boundaries and disciplinary actions. As children grow and navigate different life stages, these differences can become more pronounced, especially if not addressed early on.

Related Reading

Effective co-parenting requires open communication, compromise, and a unified front. Without these, parenting differences can strain the marital relationship, leading to deeper misunderstandings and conflicts.

16. External Family Pressures

Marriage often means merging two families, bringing along a mix of expectations and traditions. External pressures from in-laws, cultural differences, or unsolicited advice can strain a marriage.

Balancing the couple's needs with extended family demands is crucial. Without clear boundaries and open communication, these pressures can lead to resentment, potentially pushing a couple toward divorce.

17. Unrealistic Expectations

Every individual enters marriage with a set of expectations, often shaped by personal experiences, societal norms, or portrayals in media. While some expectations are reasonable, others can be unrealistic, setting the stage for disappointment and conflict.

Whether it's about roles in the household, financial achievements, or emotional support, when reality doesn't align with these lofty ideals, it can lead to feelings of inadequacy and resentment. For a marriage to thrive, it's essential for partners to communicate openly, adjust expectations, and understand that perfection is unattainable.

Unrealistic expectations, if unchecked, can become a silent threat to marital harmony.

18. Trust Issues

Trust is the bedrock of any strong relationship, and its absence can create deep fissures in the foundation of a marriage. Trust issues can stem from past betrayals, misunderstandings, or personal insecurities.

Whether it's doubts about fidelity, financial decisions, or even smaller daily matters, a lack of trust can lead to constant second-guessing and surveillance. This atmosphere of suspicion can stifle open communication and intimacy.

For a marriage to overcome trust issues, it often requires open dialogue, understanding, and sometimes professional counseling. If not addressed, persistent trust issues can erode the bond between partners, making reconciliation challenging.

19. Supporting Each Other's Goals

In a marriage, individual aspirations don't disappear; they intertwine with shared dreams.

Supporting each other's goals is pivotal for mutual growth and fulfillment. When one partner feels their ambitions are sidelined or undervalued, it can lead to feelings of resentment and stagnation.

Whether it's career advancements, personal passions, or educational pursuits, acknowledging and championing these aspirations strengthens the marital bond. Conversely, neglecting or undermining a partner's goals can create a rift, making one feel unsupported or isolated.

Successful marriages often thrive on mutual respect and encouragement, ensuring both partners feel valued in their pursuits.

Why Do People Get Divorced? Top Factors That Influence The Decision to Divorce

The 2013 survey published in the *Couple and Family Psychology: Research and Practice* journal outlined seven prevailing reasons for divorce. The participants included 36 couples, divorced in the previous 14 years.

The average length of marriage for these couples was 12.2 years. The median age of the participants was 25.4 years old.

[The study found](#) that the primary reason for divorce was lack of commitment, closely followed by infidelity and conflict in the family.

- Lack of commitment (75.0%)
- Infidelity (59.6%)
- Too much conflict in the family (57.7%)
- Young age at marriage (45.1%)
- Financial issues (36.7%)
- Substance abuse (34.6%)
- Domestic violence (23.5%)

- Severe diseases or physical incapacity (18.2%)

The causes of divorce for married couples in their 50s, 60s, and 70s are unique because of the [major life transitions](#) that occur during this time.

These changes include facing empty nests after children leave, financial issues, retirement, and declining health, which can pose considerable challenges to the relationship's longevity and ultimately cause marital problems.

Another predominant factor explaining the rising number of divorces later in life is that people after 50 often live through their second or third marriages. The studies show that these marriages are less stable.

In a 2012 [survey](#) by Hawkins, Willoughby, and Doherty, a sample of 886 divorcing parents was interviewed. The research found that common causes of divorce were:

- Distance in the relationship/lack of physical intimacy (55%)
- Communication problems between partners (53%)
- Money disagreements (40%)
- Infidelity / personal problems (37%)
- Not getting enough attention (34%)
- The spouse's habits (29%)
- Sexual issues (24%)

Other factors include economic resources and demographic characteristics (different races have different divorce rates).

Several surveys on the reasons for divorce have been conducted among various age groups and demographics. As it turned out, divorce may be caused by [low levels of educational attainment](#), certain [religious beliefs](#) or behaviors, [age](#), and [race](#).

The highest shares of divorce for the categories mentioned above are influenced by the following:

- low level of education (some college, high school, or lower): 20.4%
- protestant upbringing (Evangelical, Historically Black, Mainline): 19%
- people aged 15 to 24 years old: 27%
- Black or African American: 38.9%

According to several studies on the connection between divorce and physical or mental conditions, different risk factors may influence the decision to get divorced. The most common ones are:

- the [presence of mental disorder](#) in one of the spouses (20%)
- inability to have [children](#) (27%)
- addiction to [alcohol](#) (21.1%)

The causes of divorce for married couples in their 50s, 60s, and 70s are unique because of the major life transitions that occur during this time.

The nationwide divorce causes reflect those prevalent in the individually taken states.

For instance, in a 2017 survey conducted by scholars at Dalton State College, a sample of 191 individuals formulated the following most common reasons for divorce in Northwest Georgia:

- Infidelity (56%)
- Communication problems (31.9%)
- Abuse (21.5%)
- Financial issues (18.8%)

All in all, surveys by [Insider.com](#), [The Huffington Post](#), [Forbes](#), and the [NCBI](#) found a diversity of reasons for couples to initiate the divorce process.

- Lack of commitment (75%)
- Infidelity/relationships outside of the marriage (59.6%)

- Conflict, irreconcilable differences (57.7%)
- Marrying too young (45.1%)
- Money issues/debt (36.1%)
- Substance abuse/alcohol addiction (34.6%)
- Communication problems (31.9%)
- Inability to have children (27%)
- Domestic violence (23.5%)
- A child has a mental illness or is incapacitated (22.7%)
- Health problems, mental illness of a spouse (20%)
- Lack of support from family (17.3%)
- Religious differences (13.3%)

Conclusion

Across the various causes of divorce surveys covered in this article, the common reasons that appear in at least two or more surveys of divorced couples are:

- Infidelity
- Lack of commitment
- Alcohol addiction/substance abuse
- Financial issues
- Conflict/Irreconcilable differences

Luckily, in spite of the challenges that married couples face during the course of a relationship, the likelihood of divorce declines as the length of marriage increases.

In addition, resources like marriage counseling, relationship education and family law therapists assist couples in resolving conflict and building healthy marriages before divorce becomes inevitable.

If marriage partners are able to approach their relationship with open minds in order to avoid the disappointment of unrealistic, unmet expectations, they will remain flexible throughout their marriage to overcome the challenges they encounter.

- [Reasons for Divorce and Recollections of Premarital Intervention: Implications for Improving Relationship Education - PMC](#)
- [Does Having Children Contribute To Your Risk Of Divorce?](#)
- [In-Laws And Marriage Study: Son-In-Law Key To Lasting Marriage | HuffPost Life](#)
- [The Most Common Reasons for Divorce, Ranked](#)
- ["Variables Associated with Divorce in Northwest Georgia, 2007-2016" by Hassan A. El-Najjar](#)
- [DSM-IV Alcohol Dependence and Marital Dissolution: Evidence From the National Epidemiologic Survey on Alcohol and Related Conditions - PMC](#)
- [Divorce or end of cohabitation among Danish women evaluated for fertility problems - Kjaer - 2014 - Acta Obstetricia et Gynecologica Scandinavica - Wiley Online Library](#)
- [A multinational study of mental disorders, marriage, and divorce - PubMed](#)
- [Age Variation in the Divorce Rate, 1990 and 2017](#)
- [Marital status - Religion in America: U.S. Religious Data, Demographics and Statistics | Pew Research Center](#)
- [\(PDF\) Reasons for Divorce and Openness to Marital Reconciliation](#)
- [Dimensions of Marital Quality and Retirement - Adam Davey, Maximiliane E. Szinovacz, 2004](#)
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Leading Causes Of Divorce: 43% Report Lack Of Family Support
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No one enters their marriage wanting to get divorced. Understanding why marriages fail can help you to make your own union stronger if you are married. It can also guide you in making the right choices about entering into a marriage before you tie the knot and help you support the married couples in your life.

Forbes Advisor commissioned a survey of 1,000 Americans who are divorced or who are in the process of divorcing to discover what they have in common. Based on this data, here are some of the most likely reasons marriages come to an end.

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Key Takeaways

- The majority of divorces are initiated by only one party, with only 27% of respondents indicating the decision to end the marriage was mutual.
- 63% of divorcees believe a better understanding of the commitments of marriage could have helped them to avoid divorce.
- Lack of compatibility is the top reason for new couples to divorce, with 59% of couples who divorced in their first year citing this cause.

The State of Divorce in 2025

A total of 689,308 divorces occurred in 2021 and approximately half of all first marriages end in divorce with subsequent marriages failing at higher rates.

When a couple divorces, they must state *grounds for divorce* in court—this is the reason for ending the marriage and dictates the [type of divorce](#) being filed.

Most people choose [a no fault, divorce](#), citing irreconcilable differences. And, irreconcilable differences are indeed a common divorce cause, with 31% of couples who ended their marriages reporting that incompatibility was the reason.

However, while simply not getting along is a common reason for divorce, infidelity remains a bigger issue. In total, 34% of marriages among survey respondents ended due to an affair. Adultery is one of the grounds for a *fault divorce* in court. However, even when an extramarital affair occurs, sometimes the couple pursues a no-fault divorce instead of a fault divorce because it's simpler.

Other common causes of divorce included:

- lack of family support
- lack of intimacy
- too much conflict and
- financial stress

But, while these issues cause marriages to end, couples who divorce don't always recognize these problems as signs a marriage is in trouble. Just 21% of survey respondents said disapproval of a spouse by family or friends was a sign a marriage was at risk, despite the fact lack of family support was a leading factor in 43% of divorces.

The Most Common Reasons People Get Married

To understand the causes of divorce, it's helpful to understand the reasons people marry.

Among the divorced couples surveyed, financial security was the most common motivating factor, with 42% of respondents marrying for security.

Women were more likely than men to indicate they married for financial reasons, with 44% of women reporting this led to their union. With a persistent gender pay gap resulting in women being paid 22.2% less than men on average in 2022, it's unsurprising more women feel the need for a partner to help provide support. Love did come in a close second, though, with 39% of women saying love was their main reason for getting married.

Companionship was also a driving force, with 39% of all survey respondents indicating a desire for a companion led them to marry. This was the top reason for men to marry, with 42% citing it as their motivation. A desire to start a family was the second most common factor for men.

Other reasons couples married included making a commitment, convenience, medical insurance, legal reasons and societal and family pressures.

The Most Common Reasons for Divorcing

The most common reason for divorce was a surprising one: a lack of family support. However, there were many other reasons for unions to end, with causes of divorcing varying based on how long the couple was together.

- Those who divorced quickly were more likely to end their marriages because they discovered they couldn't get along. In fact, 59% of people who dissolved their unions within the first year of marriage cited a lack of compatibility.
- A lack of family support became a bigger issue as time went on. It was the leading reason for divorce among those who ended their marriages within years two through eight.
- Finally, long-term couples were generally prompted to divorce by very serious issues, with infidelity and a lack of intimacy causing most divorces once a couple had been married for nine or more years.

The Correlation Between the Reasons to Marry and Divorce

When a person is motivated to marry by a specific desire that goes unfulfilled, this increases the chances the union will fail. As a result, it's unsurprising there is correlation between the reasons to marry and the causes of divorce.

Most couples who married for companionship, financial security, convenience, medical insurance, legal reasons or a desire to start a family blamed a lack of compatibility for their divorce. It's not surprising that those who marry because they want a companion are more likely to end a union if they don't get along. It's also

unsurprising that people who are motivated by factors other than love—such as legal reasons, convenience, or a desire for security—may find they are not compatible with the partner they chose.

Couples who married due to societal or family pressures, on the other hand, were most likely to divorce due to extramarital affairs. These couples who felt pressure into entering into a commitment were less likely to keep it.

And those who married as a formal act of commitment were more likely to end the marriage due to a lack of intimacy. Their desire to cement the relationship via marriage may have been an indicator they felt this close connection lacking even before the nuptials.

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Warning Signs a Marriage Is at Risk

Understanding the causes of divorce can show why a marriage ended. But those who are currently married may be interested in the signs of divorce so they can identify when their own marriage may be in trouble.

A lack of interest in each other, poor conflict resolution; and avoiding each other were the most commonly-cited signs of an imminent divorce. More than four in 10 survey respondents listed each of these behaviors as worrisome signs a marriage was doomed.

On the other hand, financial stress, marrying too soon after meeting and marrying too young are the least commonly reported signs of a marriage at risk. This is contrary to popular beliefs that money is a leading cause of divorce and contrary to the popular perception that love at first sight or young love doesn't lead to lasting relationships.

Most Common Types of Conflict Divorced Couples Experienced

Divorces often follow months or even years of conflict. And, there are many reasons for disagreement among the respondents whose marriages ended.

Couples listed career choices as the most common type of conflict they experienced with their spouses, with 46% listing this issue as a cause of marital woes.

Parenting differences, conflicts over division of household labor and relationships with family were also top causes of marital conflict.

Each was cited by more than four in 10 survey respondents as a common reason for fights with their ex.

Less than 5% of Divorcees Say Their Marriage Couldn't Be Saved

The good news is, divorcees generally believe that exhibiting different behaviors could have saved their marriages.

In fact, 63% of people who divorced said having a better understanding of commitment prior to marrying could have stopped their union from collapsing. And 56% said they may not have divorced if they had a better understanding of their spouse's morals and values. More than four in 10 respondents also indicated their marriages could have been saved by waiting longer to get married and by waiting longer to start a family.

Married couples can learn from these mistakes. And those who have experienced a divorce in the past can also go into their next relationship armed with this valuable information.

Conclusion

Divorce affects the lives of millions of Americans. By better understanding common causes for divorce, as well as common signs of divorce, individuals and couples can make more informed choices within their romantic relationships.

Those who experience divorce should also make certain they understand their legal rights through the process of ending their union, and seek assistance from the best divorce lawyers who can help them protect their financial security going forward.

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Methodology

This online survey of 1,000 Americans who have been divorced or are currently getting a divorce was commissioned by Forbes Advisor and conducted by market research company OnePoll, in accordance with the Market Research Society's code of conduct. The margin of error is +/- 3.1 points with 95% confidence. This survey was overseen by the OnePoll research team, which is a member of the MRS and has corporate membership with the American Association for Public Opinion Research (AAPOR).

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12 Of The Most Common Reasons For Divorce, According To The Experts

And you might not even be familiar with some of them.

By [Alyssa Girdwain](#) Published: Apr 14, 2020 11:00 AM EDT

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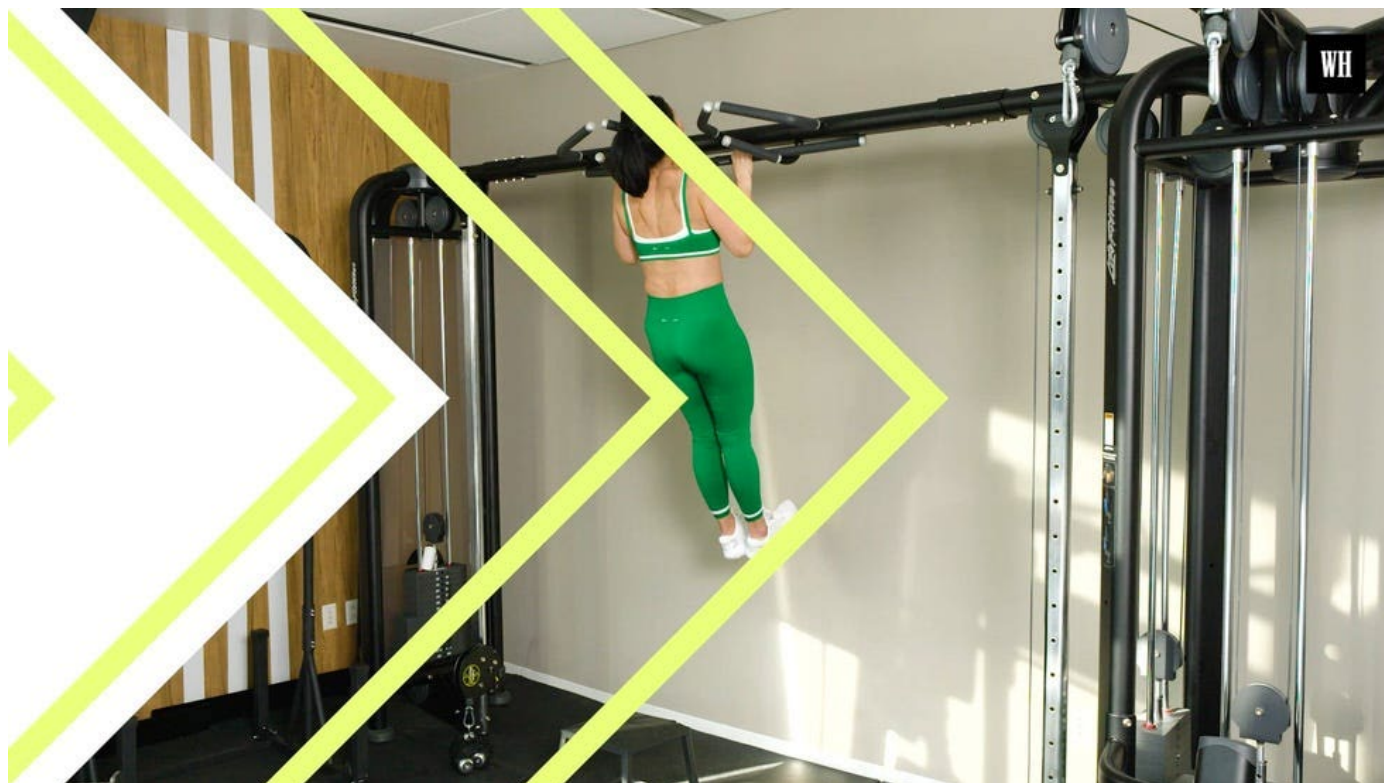
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6 min read

Breaking up is hard to do, but divorce? That takes the cake. All kinds of things can lead to a split, from the token celebrity-cited “irreconcilable differences” to a messy affair, or the loss of anything remotely close to the spark you felt in the good old days.

And often, the reason you cross the line from forever to never again traces back to your dating days. “Sometimes people want a divorce for the same reason they might have had doubts of going into the relationship,” [Elizabeth Cohen](#), PhD, a clinical psychologist in New York says. “It’s usually the things that bothered you before, they just compounded over so long that you know it’s not going to change.”

Of course, you presumably wanted to be together (at least at some point) if you got married. But it’s hard as hell for people to change in the ways you may need them to in order to maintain a healthy marriage where both of you can ~thrive~. That’s why getting a divorce can feel like a slow burn. “It’s likely the decision comes after years and years of contemplating and trying to make the marriage work,” says [Erin Levine](#), family law attorney and founder of [Hello Divorce](#), a legal assistance platform.



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While the reasons for a divorce are unique to the relationship, here are the issues that a divorce lawyer and psychologist say pop up most often:

1. Communication Problems

The crux of any relationship is communication, Cohen says. Sure, you typically hear reasons for divorce like money disagreements, commitment issues and the other things in this list, but Levine reminds us that these problems are also rooted in a breakdown of communication.

If you can't talk your ish out in a way both partners understand, all that's left is an unproductive argument and growing resentment. "Your behavior might not match what your partner needs," Cohen says. That's why divorce often waits at the bottom of that slippery slope.

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2. Falling Out Of Love

According to a study in the [Journal of Sex & Marital Therapy](#), nearly half of recently [divorced](#) respondents cited a lack of love or intimacy as the reason for their separation. Instead of one big betrayal, sometimes just growing apart and losing your romantic feelings can end a marriage. "There's this overarching feeling of distance that happens over time," Cohen says.

3. There's No Intimacy

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Along with the “I love you, but I’m not in love with you” realization, a dormant bedroom life is also a factor for divorce. There’s nothing shameful about a dry spell, but a lack of physical affection—sexy times and long bear hugs included—can cause serious disconnect. “People start telling themselves like, ‘Okay, well the lack of intimacy, I can handle that.’ But ultimately it just becomes too much for them” Levine says.

4. It’s Not A Partnership Anymore

People come to Levine's practice saying that they've felt misunderstood and unheard in the marriage. "They tell me, 'Here I am in a relationship and it feels like I'm all alone,'" she says. Though they might have full and exciting personal lives, they'll feel like they're no longer working as a unit with their spouse, whether that's because their priorities for the future of shifted or because they realize they simply don't have much in common with their partners anymore. That disconnect and [loneliness](#) can be reason enough for divorce.

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5. You Weren't Ready For Marriage

"Similarity between two partners helps predict who stays together and who doesn't," says Terri Orbuch, PhD, author of [Finding Love Again: 6 Simple Steps to a New and Happy Relationship](#) and professor at Oakland University. "If you marry too early, or haven't been able to identify who you are and what's important to you, then you can't choose the best partner." While you want to be in it for the long haul, maybe you rushed down the aisle or weren't fully in tune with yourself when you said "I do". That's when a crop of clashes—think: differing values, emotional baggage from past flings, and a lack of real trust—pop up and put you on the road to divorce.

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6. Addiction

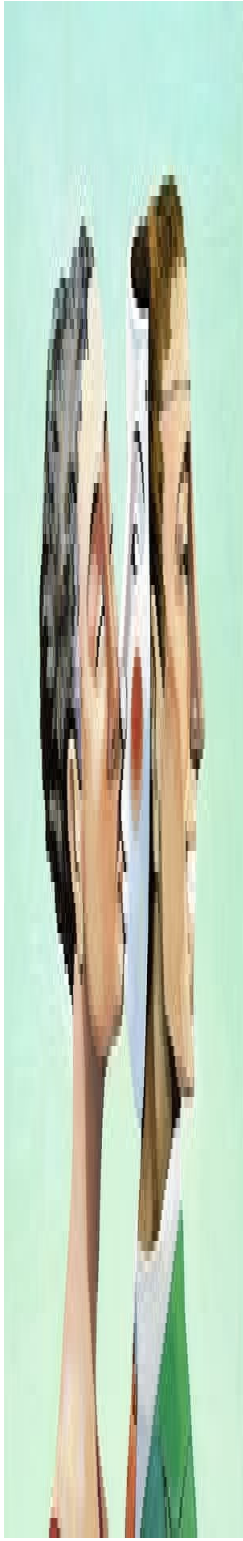
When the [National Center for Biotechnology Information](#) asked 52 people what contributed to their divorce in 2013, a third of them named substance abuse a factor that contributed to the end of their marriages. Whether it's drugs, alcohol, or another damaging vice, Levine notes that substance abuse is often a factor in divorces she sees in her practice. If a partner doesn't want to get help or they become a threat to their partner's safety, it's often a straw that breaks the camel's back.

7. Domestic Abuse

Abuse, from physical harm to emotional manipulation like a partner withdrawing affection as punishment, leaves people feeling powerless. Separating from the abusive partner—in a safe and supported way—is the best way to regain your safety. Abuse differs from other causes for divorce in that "it's not a relationship issue, but something that is within your partner," Orbuch says. In the same [NCBI](#) study, around a quarter of respondents said domestic violence led to their divorce.

8. Cheating

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Without trust, what's left? An [affair](#) can feel like the ultimate betrayal and sign that healthy communication skidded to a halt a long time ago. While Cohen notes that it can be possible to move past the infidelity together, it's a toughie. Most of the time? It's the moment that causes a partner to officially dip out.

9. Lack Of Emotional Support

“The breakdown in communication often leads to people feeling desperate, so they criticize or get angry or make demands,” Levine says. “Nobody wants to be around that or that energy.” Cohen agrees, noting she speaks to many divorced women who felt undermined, disrespected, and like they weren’t a priority in the marriage. Once empathy and compassion for one another take a nosedive, “it’s very hard to come back together,” Cohen says.

10. They’re Just Done

“People in long-term marriages are generally not just walking out on their marriages for the heck of it,” Levine says. “These are people who tried to save their marriages for years and years, and it just didn’t work out.” You’ve put in so much work to give the relationship new life, but your partner hasn’t shown the same effort. Once it becomes clear that things aren’t going to change, people pull the plug. Every little thing builds up contempt or resentment, until one morning you wake up like: “Here are your divorce papers, my guy.”

11. Financial Issues

How (and when) you spend it, save it, or make it, money is one of those things that can easily trigger tension in a marriage. Disagreements about finances make matters dicey, especially when it gets in the way of working together as a team, Cohen says. Someone might think their partner spends too much, another might be worried about their partner’s debt, and, in some cases, couples can’t compromise about what to spend their money on. Over time, the strain gets to be too much. What’s mine was once yours, but not anymore.

12. Lost Sense Of Self

We are fluid beings, and what you want can change over the course of a 20-year marriage. “Very often in relationships, a partner has been sacrificing what they want and need for the sake of keeping the marriage together,” Cohen says. Whether that’s passing up a job opportunity or getting lost in the role of “Mom,” the marriage could take you down a path you don’t identify with all that much anymore. It’s one thing to compromise, but it’s another to lose sight of your individuality completely. If you do, you might resent your partner and want out.